

The Waterfront Brief

Weekly sustainment intelligence for naval shipyard leadership · Naval shipbuilding, ship repair, and fleet sustainment

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Fleet Forces says the repairs put off to keep ships in the Middle East will hit the yards together in 2027, and one Jacksonville yard nearly lost 400 workers waiting. The Navy's maintenance chief took four months off a submarine availability by leaving repairs undone. Ships repaired abroad can come home with material the Navy did not supply, and the next yard only finds it by sampling. Pearl Harbor is training the Australians who will maintain US submarines near Perth. And Keyport is certified for cold spray, starting with a submarine valve that epoxy does not always fix.

How to read this: where a sentence names where something came from, those words are a link to the source itself, and the sentence says what that source says. A sentence with no link is this desk's analysis, built only on the linked facts above it. Two warnings are still written out in the text: Speculation, and Unverified for a claim nobody here could check against a primary source, with the reason it could not be checked.

OPERATIONS MAINTENANCE & READINESS

The repairs put off for the Middle East reach the yards together in 2027

The commander of U.S. Fleet Forces says the surface ship repairs pushed aside this year will hit the private yards at once in 2027, and one yard nearly lost 400 workers waiting.

Adm. Karl Thomas told a fleet maintenance symposium last month that major availabilities for the destroyers Thomas Hudner and Donald Cook and the littoral combat ship St. Louis moved from 2026 to 2027. He said 18 smaller maintenance periods were canceled.

Thomas said the current schedule "concentrates more than six concurrent availabilities," and that "this feast or famine dynamic is going to break our shipyards."

The Southeast Regional Maintenance Center's notice for Hudner called for a 347-day docking

period in a certified dry dock within 250 miles of Mayport. The copy found is undated.

NAVSEA's notice for St. Louis and Donald Cook lists them as fiscal 2027 docking availabilities, delivering October 4, 2027 and April 17, 2028.

USNI News reported that the shift left BAE Systems Jacksonville facing a layoff of 400 workers, until the Navy arranged a job on the littoral combat ship Wichita.

The Department of War's July 2 contract list shows that job at \$49,339,702 for a Mayport docking period, \$60,891,843 with options, finishing May 2027. USNI News put it at \$70 million.

The Congressional Budget Office reported in December 2025 that it "did not identify capacity constraints as a driver of delays in maintenance for conventional ships."

The president of the Virginia Ship Repair Association told the symposium: "We don't necessarily have a workforce problem; we have a workload problem."

Thomas described the Navy's goal as meeting maintenance needs "at the earliest feasible opportunity."

Expect the slow months before 2027 to be the harder problem for the yards. This year ran against Thomas's stated goal, with small periods canceled and big ones pushed back. The budget office found the docks can take conventional work; Jacksonville shows the workforce may not wait for it. The Navy has already paid once to keep a yard's trades together, so more bridge jobs like Wichita's are likely. When the work arrives, more than six availabilities running at once will all draw on the same people, material and planners in the same months.

WHY IT MATTERS

Bottom line: Dock space has not been what delays surface ships. In 2027, with six or more availabilities at once, something else will run out first: people, material, planners or approvals. Find out which one it is for you and start on it now.

Sources: USNI News, Sep 23, 2026; SERMC notice via BidNet, undated; NAVSEA notice N00024-26-R-4405 via HigherGov; Department of War contracts, Jul 2, 2026; CBO, Dec 10, 2025

The Navy's maintenance chief took four months off a submarine availability by leaving repairs undone

Rear Adm. Todd Weeks says his office cut a public-yard submarine availability from 29 months to 25 by agreeing with the fleet to skip some repairs, and he wants more decisions made that way.

Rear Adm. Todd Weeks, the Portfolio Acquisition Executive for Industrial Operations, told the Fleet Maintenance and Modernization Symposium, "We absolutely need to change, and we're not getting it done."

Weeks said his office, at the operational commander's request, "trimmed four months off a public yard availability for a submarine through direct conversations over the risk of curtailing some of the repairs." He put the result as "the submarine delivered in 25 months instead of 29." The report names neither the boat nor the yard.

Weeks said such calls now get made "in this room," and that the Navy is done "driving technical risk to zero and shifting all this operational risk back to the fleet."

Capt. Dan Hemminger, who commands the Mid-Atlantic Regional Maintenance Center, told a deferral panel at the same symposium that "different people own that risk." He listed "the impact on the industrial base resulting from decreased planned workload."

GAO reported in May 2022 that "the Navy generally does not defer depot-level maintenance on its submarines due to strict safety requirements."

GAO found that three of 31 submarine depot periods from fiscal 2015 to 2019 deferred any depot work. The largest was 502 labor days on USS Greeneville, against 67,616 completed.

The same GAO report says the Navy moved those items "in subsequent intermediate-level maintenance periods after a technical review." It quotes Navy policy that work "essential for safe and reliable nuclear propulsion plant operations will not be deferred."

GAO reported in August that the average attack submarine depot period grew from 744 days in fiscal 2016 to 2020 to 809 days in 2021 to 2025.

Expect the cut repairs to turn up later at the waterfront. Four months on one boat is more than the whole growth in the average depot period GAO measured, and far beyond the deferrals GAO counted. Propulsion work cannot be cut, so the skipped items were other work. The last time the Navy deferred submarine depot work, it went to later intermediate periods after a technical review. This time the fleet asked for the cut and got it through direct conversations, so expect more of them, with less review behind each.

WHY IT MATTERS

Bottom line: An availability that finishes early by cutting repairs still owes those repairs. When work is cut, get the list, and make sure the period that inherits it is planned and staffed for it.

Sources: USNI News, Sep 24, 2026; Mid-Atlantic Regional Maintenance Center via DVIDS, Sep 29, 2026; GAO-22-105032, May 9, 2022; GAO-26-109256, Aug 27, 2026

Ships repaired abroad can come home with material the Navy did not supply

USS Ross got a voyage repair in Mombasa last month with help from local industry, and the Navy's own maintenance manual says contractors in ports like that do not get Navy-specification parts or material.

The Navy said on September 18 that the Forward Deployed Regional Maintenance Center finished the repair aboard USS Ross in Mombasa on September 10, "partnering with local industry." The release names no company.

The Chief of Naval Operations, Adm. Daryl Caudle, named Kenya, Diego Garcia and India as possible port calls "in locations less vulnerable to attack from Iran," Military Times reported on August 26.

The Joint Fleet Maintenance Manual, Volume III, paragraph 3.4.1, says that outside Yokosuka and Sasebo, Military Specification "parts and material are not available to local contractors in other ports," lagging excepted. The same paragraph requires "no less stringent QA procedures than any other routine planned repair."

A 2023 peer-reviewed analysis in Public Health Action found that India has stopped mining asbestos but still imports and processes chrysotile "in large quantities."

Australia's maritime safety regulator warns that "asbestos containing components may also find their way into a ship during operational maintenance," and calls for re-inspection after maintenance and refit work.

NAVSEA Standard Item 009-010, paragraph 3.1, states that shipboard insulation, lagging, deck tile, underlayment, gaskets, cabling and mastic are to be treated as asbestos-containing. That holds "until it can be established by laboratory analysis, or other reliable method(s)" that they are not, and the item sets no hull-age limit.

Standard Item 009-032, paragraph 3.1.1, states that marine coatings and decking systems are to be considered to contain heavy metals, lead among them.

OSHA's shipyard asbestos rule presumes asbestos only in insulation and surfacing material on vessels "constructed no later than 1980," and lets an owner or employer rebut that presumption. It requires the vessel owner to find asbestos before work begins.

For a contractor working to the Standard Items, a forward repair changes nothing: gaskets, insulation and paint are presumed hazardous on every hull until a lab says otherwise. The risk is for anyone who clears material from records instead of sampling it. Any hull built after 1980 falls outside OSHA's presumption, and the paperwork may not show what a local contractor installed. Expect the first find on a newer hull to be a gasket or a patch of insulation replaced abroad, cleared from records and cut without a sample.

WHY IT MATTERS

Bottom line: A ship repaired in a foreign port may carry material the Navy did not supply. Find out what the local contractor worked on, and test those systems for asbestos and lead before anyone cuts into them. Put the sampling and lab time at the front of your schedule.

Sources: U.S. Navy, Sep 18, 2026; Military Times, Aug 26, 2026; Joint Fleet Maintenance Manual, Vol. III, Change 5; Public Health Action, Jun 21, 2023; Australian Maritime Safety Authority, as read 2026-10-02; NAVSEA Standard Item 009-010, FY-27; NAVSEA Standard Item 009-032, FY-27; 29 CFR 1915.1001

WATERFRONT OPS & PRODUCTION

Pearl Harbor is training the Australians who will maintain US submarines in Western Australia

Eight Australian navy divers spent five months on Pearl Harbor's dive teams, an early step toward Australians doing most of the maintenance on US submarines based near Perth from 2027.

The Navy said on September 22 that eight Royal Australian Navy divers spent five months on Pearl Harbor's dive teams, swapping components inside flooded ballast tanks and inspecting torpedo tubes on Virginia-class boats. It says they then worked USS Vermont at Stirling, near Perth, in November 2025 and the British submarine Anson there in February 2026.

AUKUS defense ministers confirmed on May 30 that Submarine Rotational Force-West will be established in 2027.

Australia's defense minister said on June 12 that "more than 220 Australian industry personnel" were at Pearl Harbor, and that more than 10 had gone home since December 2025.

Pearl Harbor would stand up a detachment in Western Australia in mid-2026 to "oversee and execute" maintenance on the US boats, USNI News reported on June 11. Neither the report nor the Navy gives its size.

When Pearl Harbor took on this work in 2023, its commander said "we can't absorb this added workload with our current workforce" and planned to hire across "numerous shops," the Navy said then. No public figure says how many were hired.

The Navy said in February that Pearl Harbor's "flyaway workforce provided the technical backbone." Australia's defense department had said in October 2025 that Pearl-trained Australians would "help deliver the majority of the maintenance effort."

Pearl Harbor finished USS Colorado's maintenance 29 days early with the training load already running, USNI News reported in June.

Expect Pearl Harbor's own flyaway supervisors and divers to carry the first 2027 rotations. More than 10 of more than 220 trainees had gone home by June, and the detachment is set to execute work as well as oversee it. The Australian share

grows only as the rest return. Colorado finished early before the detachment left, so it does not show Pearl can spare those people. If the 2023 hiring fell short, it will show first in Pearl's own Virginia-class availabilities.

WHY IT MATTERS

Bottom line: Training partners and staffing overseas detachments both pull divers and supervisors away from home work. If your 2027 work depends on those people, ask how many are committed elsewhere before you count on them.

Sources: U.S. Navy, Sep 22, 2026; AUKUS defense ministers' joint statement, May 30, 2026; Australian defense minister's office, Jun 12, 2026; USNI News, Jun 11, 2026; U.S. Navy, Aug 3, 2023; U.S. Navy, Feb 20, 2026; Australian defense department, Oct 29, 2025

MAINTENANCE ENGINEERING & TECHNOLOGIES

Keyport is certified for cold spray, starting with a submarine valve that epoxy does not always fix

NAVSEA has certified Keyport's cold spray facility, and Keyport is writing the repair procedures Puget Sound and Bangor would use on submarine three-way ball valves.

Naval Undersea Warfare Center Division, Keyport said on September 28 that it is "the second Warfare Center to receive official approval from Naval Sea Systems Command for its cold spray facility and quality assurance program." The approval covers "non-structural cold spray repairs using approved materials widely used throughout the Navy."

Keyport says it is writing "Qualified Spray Procedures" for Puget Sound Naval Shipyard and the Trident Refit Facility at Bangor.

The Submarine Industrial Base program paid for testing aimed at three-way ball valves, which the release calls "a major cause of delays in submarine maintenance." It says the epoxy used on them today "may crack or fail to stick during curing," and a failed patch is baked off and the repair starts over.

Keyport estimates, from historical shipyard data, that cold spray could cut valve repair turnaround

by 9 to 15 percent and repair attempts by up to 42 percent. These are projections.

The release also says mast and radar shaft repairs wait on a move to a larger space, and round-the-clock spraying waits on a nitrogen generator still being bought. Structural repair of pressurized piping is in development with Naval Nuclear Laboratory.

A NAVSEA official said in 2023 that the public shipyards "either have or are getting this capability," USNI News reported. NAVSEA's chief engineer at the time said cold spray helps "for getting after some repairs," adding "not all."

Expect the first payoff to be narrow: one valve type at Puget Sound and Bangor that stops coming back for a second repair. The yards had or were getting cold spray equipment by 2023, so the qualified procedure is the new piece. Masts, shafts and piping wait on space, gas supply and a structural qualification with no date. The 42 percent stays an estimate until a yard reports valves that held.

WHY IT MATTERS

Bottom line: If a part on your job is usually patched with epoxy, ask whether a cold spray procedure is approved for it yet. Keep epoxy in the plan until one is, and do not count on the projected savings until parts repaired this way have held up in service.

Sources: NUWC Division, Keyport via DVIDS, Sep 28, 2026; USNI News, Sep 12, 2023

BUSINESS PRACTICES & STRATEGY

No leadership column this week; nothing in the pipeline had a study behind it.

The Waterfront Brief is compiled weekly by the B2 vault's research engine from primary sources and verified trade reporting. Scope: US shipbuilding, US Navy sustainment, and partners across the Indo-Pacific region; out-of-area items only when there is a direct, stated lesson. Freshness policy: every article's anchor source is under 12 months old; older material appears only as dated context or a flagged exception. A linked sentence means the named source says it, not that this desk has independently verified it. Corrections welcome; staged sources are retained for audit.

UPCOMING EVENTS

Nearest first, filling the page. **Bold** marks a decision that closes inside the next 60 days.

Dates	Event	Register by	Why it matters
Oct 20-21, 2026	NSRP Workforce & Compliance and Production Planning Joint Panel, Pensacola, FL (NSRP)	In-person closes Oct 8	Workforce and production-planning panels, jointly; virtual option
Oct 28-30, 2026	SNAME Maritime Convention 2026, Royal Sonesta Houston Galleria, Houston, TX (SNAME)	Not printed	Workforce pipeline: naval architects, marine engineers and yard production people in one technical program
Nov 12-13, 2026	Naval Submarine League Annual Symposium 2026, Arlington, VA (NSL)	To be posted	Submarine industrial base: the submarine force and its yards set the year's priorities
Dec 8-11, 2026	Department of War Maintenance Symposium 2026, Fort Lauderdale, FL (SAE for DoW)	Open; rates rise after Nov 7	Maintenance execution: the department-wide depot maintenance meeting
Jan 12-14, 2027	SNA National Symposium 2027, Arlington, VA (SNA)	Not yet open	Program priorities: where the surface force states its maintenance priorities
Jan 26-28, 2027	Military Additive Manufacturing Summit (MILAM), Tampa, FL (DSI)	Early rate closed Oct 2	Additive qualification: defense additive qualification and NAVSEA-spec adoption
Feb 8-10, 2027	NDIA Annual Logistics Forum 2027, Renaissance Orlando at SeaWorld, Orlando, FL (NDIA)	Not printed	Supply chain: lifecycle sustainment and supply-chain community (the 41st forum)
Feb 16-18, 2027	WEST 2027, San Diego, CA (AFCEA/USNI)	Not printed	Program priorities: the Pacific-side sea services conference
Mar 23-25, 2027	NSRP All Panel Meeting 2027, North Charleston, SC (NSRP)	"Coming soon"	Regional capacity: where yard R&D ideas get teamed program-wide
Apr 4-7, 2027	Sea-Air-Space 2027, National Harbor, MD (Navy League)	Not yet open	Program priorities: the largest US maritime defense exposition
Apr 11-15, 2027	AMPP Annual Conference + Expo 2027, Columbus, Ohio (AMPP)	Abstracts closed Oct 1; attendee registration not printed	Preservation: the corrosion and coatings profession's main event
Jun 8-10, 2027	MegaRust 2027, Hampton, VA (ASNE)	Attendee registration not yet open	Maintenance execution: the Navy corrosion event